

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY

PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

MODULE 1: EVOLUTION OF INDIAN FOREIGN POLICY

Introduction

- The **policy of promoting one's ideals, interests, objectives and other principles is referred to as the foreign policy of a country** which constantly changes in response to the changing conditions, both at the domestic level and at the international stage.
- Foreign policy refers to a **government's strategy in dealing with other nations**. It encompasses a wide range of activities, including **diplomacy, trade negotiations, military alliances, and international aid**. The primary goal of foreign policy is **to safeguard a nation's interests, security, and prosperity on the global stage**.
- India is one of the most ancient civilisations in the world, and from ancient times, **India's foreign policy remained independent**, whether it was the Mauryan Empire, the Gupta Empire or the Mughal Empire.
- The British were the determinants of India's foreign policy during the colonial period, who used India for their benefit. But after independence, India's foreign policy is again fulfilling Indian interests.
- Foreign policy of a nation is shaped by several factors including its **history, culture, geography and economy, domestic and international milieu**. Elements of continuity and change in a country's foreign policy can be explained with reference to the important influence of these factors and forces.
- The foreign policy of India or any country is shaped by two factors: **domestic and international**.
- Domestically, India's history, culture, geography and economy have played an important role in determining the objectives and principles of India's foreign policy.
- The **international factor** is marked by the Cold War rivalry between **NATO and the Warsaw Pact**, the founding of the UN, the weapons race, notably the nuclear arms race, anti-colonialism and anti-imperialism, etc.
- The **3 S's: Space** for Strategic Autonomy, **Stability**: Both Within and in the Neighbourhood, **Strength**: Economic, Military, and Soft Power to Protect and Advance Indian Interests, have been mentioned by many specialists as the best way to summarise the objectives of Indian Foreign Policy.
- Today, India is in selected countries of the world in military field, space, religious culture etc. and India has used them better in its foreign policy formulation.

Objectives and Principles of India's Foreign Policy

India's foreign policy has evolved as a blend of **national interests** and **international responsibilities**. Rooted in the ideals of peace, justice, and cooperation, it aims to safeguard India's security and socio-economic development while contributing to global harmony.

Basic Objectives of India's Foreign Policy

1. Safeguarding National Interest and Sovereignty

- Protecting **territorial integrity** and **political independence** remains the foremost objective.
- **Example**: During India's chairmanship of the **Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO)**, PM Modi emphasized respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity of member states.

2. Promotion of International Peace and Security

- India advocates for **peaceful coexistence**, non-interference in internal affairs, disarmament, and conflict resolution through dialogue.
- **Example:** India's significant contributions to **UN Peacekeeping Forces** highlight its commitment to global stability.

3. Promoting Internal Development and Well-Being

- Foreign policy is leveraged to accelerate **economic growth, technology transfer, and inclusive development**.
- **Example:** Trade and investment pacts such as **India-Singapore CECA, India-Japan EPA, and India-Korea CEPA** promote mutual economic cooperation.

4. Enhancing Security

- India addresses both **traditional and non-traditional security threats** through strategic partnerships and counterterrorism cooperation.
- **Example:** Restrictions on bidders from land-border-sharing countries aimed at curbing undue Chinese influence.

5. Advancing Global Standing

- India aspires to play a **leadership role** in shaping international norms, multilateralism, and global governance.
- **Example:** India's **G20 presidency, SCO chairmanship**, and participation in **G7 (as an invitee)** reflect its rising global stature.

6. Protecting Indian Diaspora

- India values its **17.5 million-strong diaspora** (Global Migration Report 2020) and actively works for their safety and rights.
- **Example:** Evacuation operations such as **Operation Devi Shakti (Afghanistan), Operation Ganga (Ukraine), and Operation Kaveri (Sudan)** underline India's commitment.

Principles Guiding India's Foreign Policy

- **Panchsheel (Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence)**: mutual respect, non-aggression, non-interference, equality, and peaceful coexistence.
- **Non-Alignment**: pursuing strategic autonomy, resisting Cold War bloc politics, and maintaining independent decision-making.
- **Anti-Colonialism, Anti-Imperialism, and Anti-Racism**: support for liberation struggles and racial equality worldwide.
- **Peaceful Settlement of Disputes**: rejection of force in resolving international conflicts.
- **Strengthening Multilateralism**: commitment to the **United Nations**, regional organizations, and development of international law.

Evolution of India's Foreign Policy

- The **evolution of India's foreign policy can be traced back to the pre-independence days of the Indian National Movement**.
- The **meeting of the All-India Congress Committee in New Delhi in 1921** was "a landmark in the history of India's foreign relations". For the first time, the **Congress passed a resolution on foreign policy**, which included the statement that "the present government of India in no way represents Indian opinion".
- The **All India Congress Committee passed another important resolution in its session held at Madras in 1927**, which stressed the need **to conduct independently the external relations of India with the rest of the world without the interference of the British**

government. Indeed, the foundations of India's foreign policy had been laid down at the **Madras Session of the Congress.**

- An assessment of the Congress resolutions from **1921 to 1947** reveals "an acute awareness of the dangers in the growth of fascism, a sympathetic approach to the aspirations of the Soviet Union, a consistent criticism of the continuation or expansion of Western imperial power anywhere in the world, and a sensitive exposure of all forms of racial, social, and economic discrimination".
- Since its independence, **Indian foreign policy has advocated the principles of friendship and cooperation with all the countries of the world,** irrespective of their political systems. Especially the **establishment of friendly relations with the neighbouring countries was the principal plank** of India's foreign policy.
- The post-Independence foreign policy was formulated on the **principle of non-alignment** because India achieved its independence during the time when the **Cold War clouds were already looming large on the globe**, as a result of which it not only underwent but also experienced the power politics of the Super Powers.

India under Nehru

- Jawaharlal Nehru played a **decisive and dynamic** role in the evolution of India's foreign policy. Nehru is aptly regarded as the **main architect of India's foreign policy.**
- Nehru laid out certain foreign policy goals in a broadcast from New Delhi on **7 September 1946**: end of colonialism and racism, independence from power blocs, and close ties with China and Asian neighbours.
- Nehru declared that **India would always keep away from power politics.** He also asserted that, "wherever freedom is menaced or justice threatened or where aggression takes place, we cannot be and shall not be neutral".
- **Non-alignment is a positive thought;** it meant that **India retained the independence of decision-making** on an issue that affected its interests.
- During the time of Nehru, India faced many challenges ranging from **poverty alleviation at the domestic front to the issue of the Cold War at the international platform.** India needed a period of **peace and stability** to spur economic growth and political stability.

Nehru and Panchsheel

- The word '**Panchsheel**' denotes 'five precepts or virtues', which used to govern the personal behavior of Indian monks as described in the **ancient Buddhist scriptures.** Under Nehru, this idea was to become a central theme guiding the relationship among international states.
- The same principle was proposed to govern the **India-China relationship,** which was enshrined in a trade pact between the two countries, streamlining their bilateral trade operations on Tibet.

India and China agreed to follow the following five principles in conduct of their relationship:

1. Mutual respect for each other's territorial integrity and sovereignty
 2. Mutual non-aggression
 3. Mutual non-interference
 4. Equality and mutual benefit
 5. Peaceful co-existence
- During the **1955 Bandung Conference of 29 Afro-Asian countries,** the Panchsheel tenets were incorporated into the **Ten Principles of International Peace and Cooperation.** The **United Nations General Assembly** also unanimously accepted these tenets **in 1957.** The same were also accepted as the **core principles of the Non-Alignment Movement.**

- Essentially, these principles stand for **non-use of force, approach of tolerance, and peaceful co-existence**. They allow all nations to work towards **peace and prosperity in cooperation, while maintaining their national identity**.

Non-Alignment Movement (NAM)

- Non-alignment aimed to **maintain national independence in foreign affairs by not joining any of the military alliances formed by the USA and Soviet Union** in the aftermath of the Second World War.
- Non-alignment was **neither neutrality nor non-involvement nor isolationism**. It was a dynamic concept that meant **not committing to any military bloc** but taking an **independent stand** on international issues according to the merits of each case.
- Nehru saw in non-alignment a guarantee of India's independence in the field of foreign policy.
- India played an important role in forging the non-aligned movement. **NAM was conceived by five leaders: Jawaharlal Nehru, Gamal Abdel Nasser (Egypt), Sukarno (Indonesia), Kwame Nkrumah (Ghana) and Yugoslavia's Josip Broz Tito**.
- The **first summit of the NAM was held in Belgrade in 1961**. The Non-Aligned Movement was a group of newly independent states that refused to accept the dictates of the former colonial masters.

NAM was crucial for India for at least two reasons:

- The Non-Alignment Movement **allowed India to take independent international decisions** based on merit which served its interests.
- It **enabled India to balance the two superpowers**, as neither of the superpowers could pressurise India or take her for granted.
- The Non-Alignment Movement reflected an ideology that a **sovereign state, no matter how big or small, can pursue an independent foreign policy** based on its own assessment and need.
- The movement was also a recognition of the **need to democratise the international institutions**, which is still very much relevant in the backdrop of the demand of emerging countries to give them a greater share in the international bodies like the **UN, WTO and World Bank**.

Kashmir Issue

- Kashmir, as a most important **single factor of India's external relations, brought the Cold War to the Indian subcontinent**, resulting in a heavy expenditure on military armaments.
- The **United Nations Security Council** passed a resolution proposing that the **Kashmir dispute should be resolved through mutual negotiations between India and Pakistan**, and also spoke about a **plebiscite**.
- India ruled out the options of either holding a plebiscite as proposed by the UN Security Council or accepting any outside intervention.
- Since there was no breakthrough, Pakistan decided to acquire Kashmir by **waging an undeclared war against India**, and resolved to resort to non-peaceful means to achieve its aims.

Indo-China Relation and War

- Nehru was of the view that India and China had **so much in common** as both countries had suffered at the hands of colonial powers. India voiced support for the representation of China in the **United Nations Security Council**.
- India did not support the US position in declaring China an aggressor state in the **Korean War**.

Tibetan Crisis

- After the **Chinese Revolution of 1949**, China wanted to incorporate the Tibet region and claimed it as an integral part of China.
- In **1950**, China attacked the eastern part of the region and occupied the **Chamdo region**. While India protested against this aggression, it offered to mediate which was rejected by China.
- Under the **Panchsheel Agreement (1954)**, India voluntarily gave up its military, communication and postal, and other rights over Tibet. **India recognised China's claim over the Tibet region**. China assured India that Tibet would be given much greater autonomy, though the commitment remained elusive.

1962 Chinese Attack

- The **1962 Indo-China war** was a **border dispute** which culminated into war. Two issues that led to the dispute:
 - Tibet used to be a buffer state in the past, but its annexation by China complicated the border issue.
 - The border between India and China was decided by the **McMahon Line** during the British era. China refused to recognize this line.
- India learned of a **1,200 km Chinese military highway that passed through Aksai Chin** only in September 1957. China also started showing the region as its territory in its maps.
- These border disputes finally led to the war in **1962** when **China launched a swift and massive attack on both Aksai Chin and NEFA**. China withdrew swiftly but **retained Aksai Chin, leaving NEFA in Indian control**.
- Nehru faced his first **no-confidence motion** over his failure to properly assess the Chinese intentions. Within two years, **China conducted a nuclear test (1964)**, and India had to increase defence investments.
- The **Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation (1971)** later deepened ties with the USSR, while **China improved its relationship with the USA** during the same Cold War era.

Foreign Policy under Lal Bahadur Shastri

- Shastri mostly **continued Nehru's policy of Non-Alignment**, but also built closer ties with the Soviet Union.

Sirima-Shastri Pact (1964)

- To settle the issue of Indian Tamils in the then Ceylon, **Shastri signed an accord with Sri Lanka on 30 October 1964**. This removed a persistent cause of unpleasantness between India and Ceylon.
- According to the agreement, **525,000 Indian Tamils were to be granted Indian citizenship** (and repatriated to India), while **300,000 were to be granted Sri Lankan citizenship**. This settlement was to be done by **31 October 1981**.
- However, **in 1982, India declined to consider any further applications for citizenship**, stating that the 1964 agreement had lapsed.

China's Nuclear Explosion (1964)

- China tested its atomic bomb on **16 October 1964** during Shastri's time. Though **China asserted a "no first use" policy**, it created a sense of insecurity not only in India but also in the other countries of the South Asian region.
- During the Shastri period, the **pro-bomb supporters forced India to go in for the Nuclear Bomb**. Thus, Nehru's era of influence started declining as far as the nuclear weapons policy is concerned.

India-Pakistan War (1965)

- The **1965 war** has been considered as an important development in the history of India's foreign relations. The India-Pakistan war of 1965 was an undeclared war.

Reasons for the War:

- In 1965, the situation in Kashmir became volatile as the followers of **Sheikh Abdullah** created a great deal of unrest in the valley.
- Pakistan was equipped with **superior military weapons which it had acquired from the USA**. Pakistan also wanted to strike before India could improve its defences after the debacle of the Sino-India war of 1962.
- Pakistan was also **emboldened by the closer ties with China** which aimed at isolating India.

Tashkent Declaration

- The **Tashkent Declaration** was signed between **India and Pakistan under the good offices of the Soviet Union**.
- Both parties agreed to **withdraw from all occupied areas and return to pre-war positions**. They also agreed to repatriate the prisoners of war and not resort to force.
- However, the **Tashkent Declaration failed to resolve the core issue of Kashmir**.
- No country, except Malaysia and Singapore, was prepared to come out openly to support India. The Soviet Union also chose to assume a posture of neutrality when it came to pulling up Pakistan.
- **Note:** Prime Minister **Lal Bahadur Shastri died in Tashkent on 11 January 1966**, the day after signing the declaration — one of the most significant facts associated with this event.

Foreign Policy under Indira Gandhi

- Indira Gandhi largely **followed a policy of Non-Alignment, but her policy was more realistic than idealistic**. The main objective was to **regain India's lost position in the world**.

Bangladesh Crisis

- In **1970**, a free election was held in Pakistan, in which **Bengal's Awami Party** under the leadership of **Sheikh Mujibur Rahman** won more than 98 per cent of seats in East Pakistan.
- The **Army refused to let the Awami Party form the government**. The Awami Party launched a civil disobedience movement, and the army launched a massive crackdown in East Pakistan, which led to the fleeing of lakhs of people to India.
- The Indian government showed patience to make world powers aware of the **East Pakistan repression**, and the burden falling on India due to the refugee issue. **India extended moral and material support to the freedom struggle in Bangladesh**.
- Support for Pakistan came from the US and China. To counter this threat, **India signed a 20-year Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation on 9 August 1971**.
- Within ten days, the Indian army had surrounded Dhaka from three sides, and the **Pakistani army of about 90,000 had to surrender**.
- India declared a unilateral ceasefire. Later, the **Shimla Agreement between Indira Gandhi and Zulfikar Ali Bhutto on 2 July 1972** formalised the return to peace.

Shimla Declaration (1972): Outcomes

- Except for some strategic points, **India agreed to return the Pakistani territory it had occupied during the war**.
- **Pakistan pledged to respect the Line of Control (LoC)** and not to alter it unilaterally.

- Both countries agreed to **settle their issues bilaterally** rather than by outside mediation.
- India agreed to return prisoners of war to Pakistan conditional on a Pakistan-Bangladesh agreement.

Positive outcomes of the Bangladesh crisis for India:

- India regained lost pride and self-respect that it had lost during the 1962 war.
- Around **10 million refugees** were sent back to their homes.
- **India emerged as a regional power in South Asia.**
- India's prestige at the world stage rose to a new high and its morale boosted.

Revival of Diplomatic Relations with China and Pakistan

- India demonstrated its capabilities in the 1971 war, the nuclear explosion of 1974, and the merger of Sikkim in 1975. India wanted **to reduce its dependence on the USSR** after the 1971 treaty. China also wanted to reduce Soviet influence in South Asia.
- **India unilaterally announced restoring diplomatic relations with China** to normalise the long-standing strained relationship. China welcomed the move and reciprocated by restoring diplomatic relations.
- The **Shimla Agreement of 1972** finally led to the normalisation of relationship and revival of diplomatic relations between India and Pakistan.

Relationship with Soviet Union

- India was threatened by China and Pakistan, whereas the USA openly supported Pakistan. **This led to India and the Soviet Union moving closer to each other.**
- By the 1970s, the Soviet Union became the **second largest buyer of Indian goods** while helping India in setting up of Heavy Industries, and supplying sophisticated military equipment.

Indo-Soviet Treaty (1971)

- India and the Soviet Union signed a **20-year treaty of peace, friendship and co-operation**, legalising the rapidly developing friendship and co-operation between the two countries.
- When India conducted nuclear tests in **Pokhran (1974)**, almost all the nuclear powers criticised it, **except France and the Soviet Union**, which kept a steady silence.

Relationship with the USA

- During the first phase of Indira Gandhi's leadership, the **relationship with the USA deteriorated** due to the latter's effort to build a close relationship with China, taking sides with Pakistan during the Bangladesh crisis, and due to the establishment of an American naval base in **Diego Garcia (in the Indian Ocean)**.
- During the **second phase of Indira Gandhi's leadership**, the USA helped India get IMF loans and fuel for the **Tarapur Nuclear Plant**. There was also an increase in cooperation in the fields of trade, science and technology.

Differences Over Diego Garcia

- The US decided to develop **Diego Garcia**, a strategic island in the Indian Ocean, as a strong naval base to safeguard its interests in Asia and to check the growing Russian power.
- India strongly opposed the superpower rivalry in the Indian Ocean, feeling that the development of Diego Garcia as a military base would **certainly increase the tension** not only between the superpowers, but also in the South Asian region.

Rajiv Gandhi Years

- Rajiv Gandhi **followed the foreign policy laid down by Nehru and Indira Gandhi**, but also differed from them on certain grounds, thus creating his independent foreign policy to an extent.
- His policy was aimed at **amity and goodwill amongst mankind**. For this, he advocated for a **better world economic order and nuclear disarmament**.

In January 1985, he pledged himself to pursue the following goals:

1. World Peace
2. Friendship with all nations on the basis of reciprocity and mutual benefit
3. Non-Alignment
4. New world economic order based on Justice, mutual cooperation, peace and development
5. Respect for the Independence of other states and for the principles of sovereign equality of nations, non-interference and non-intervention in their internal affairs
6. Strengthening the deep historical and cultural links with our immediate neighbours in South Asia
7. Peaceful co-existence
8. Adherence to the twin principles of continuity and change, stability and dynamism, in the changing context of world politics
9. Under his leadership, **India tilted towards the West** to get the technological know-how rather than seeking assistance from the Soviet Union, thus differing from his predecessors.

Disarmament Efforts

- Rajiv Gandhi voiced his support for **nuclear disarmament** in various forums, especially during the years **1985-86**, advocating for total elimination of nuclear weapons within a time-bound programme, including all nuclear-weapon powers in the process.

Commitment to Non-Alignment Movement

- Rajiv Gandhi **reaffirmed India's commitment to the NAM in 1985**, focusing especially on achieving more cohesion in the NAM to meet new challenges, particularly towards important economic issues.
- Rajiv Gandhi emphasized that **environment protection and issues of development** were inexorably intertwined, putting great effort towards the creation of a **Planet Protection Fund (under UN auspices)** to conserve energy and combat atmospheric pollution.

Rajiv Gandhi and Indian Ocean

- Britain handed over **Diego Garcia, the Indian Ocean island, to the USA**, opening the floodgates for the Cold War hegemony in the region.
- Rajiv Gandhi strongly advocated for **transforming the Indian Ocean into an arena of Peace, stability and cooperation** and to insulate it from Cold War politics.

Efforts to Strengthen SAARC

- India fully realized the potential of SAARC as an historic opportunity to overcome the contentious bilateral, political disputes with her neighbours through regional cooperation.
- Rajiv Gandhi emphasized that the objective of the SAARC should be towards the **attainment of collective self-reliance** and to strengthen the forces of multilateralism and world-wide cooperation.

Peace Mission to Sri Lanka

- On **29 July 1987**, **Mr. Rajiv Gandhi and Mr. J.R. Jayewardene** signed at Colombo the famous **Indo-Sri Lanka Accord** under which India agreed to send its peacekeeping force to Sri Lanka to help fight the menace of the LTTE.

- The **Indian Peacekeeping Forces (IPKF)** faced resistance from the LTTE but also from Sinhalese politicians and opposition leaders in India. The **IPKF was pulled out under PM V.P. Singh on 24 March 1990.**

Narasimha Rao Period

- Following the **1991 parliamentary elections**, **P.V. Narasimha Rao became India's 9th Prime Minister.**
- The **end of the Cold War brought many changes in the international order.** The era of bipolar world politics came to an end in 1991. After the disintegration of the Soviet Union, the **USA retained its position as the sole superpower.**

Restructuring India's Foreign Policy

- **Economic Reforms:** Deregulating the economy, loosening the state control system, opening up to the world economically, and encouraging the private economy to go forward. This policy of reform was welcomed by the US and other industrialised nations.
- **International Relations:** Indian foreign policy under P.V. Narasimha Rao was greatly focused on building relations with the US, the European Union, Russia, China, Japan, Israel, Brazil, South Africa and economically stable nations in Southeast Asia.
- India's relation with the US gradually improved after 1991. India extended its relations with the NATO member nations and successfully **established full diplomatic relations with Israel in 1992.**
- The greatest achievement of P.V. Narasimha Rao in the field of country's foreign policy was the **signing of peace agreements with China** with a view to ending the longstanding border dispute between the two countries.

Liberalization and Change of Foreign Policy

- The **New Economic Policy of 1991** brought wide-ranging changes in the foreign policy as well as economic sphere of the country.
- The government unveiled the **New Economic Policy**, aimed for the pursuit of equity and social justice and to achieve sustained high growth.

End of Bipolar World and India's Foreign Policy

- India had very close economic, cultural and technological ties with the USSR. The Soviet Union had supported India on many issues ranging from Kashmir to the Bangladesh crisis.
- The end of the Cold War opened up many challenges for India, including uncertainty on **supply of weapons systems, supply of spare parts, diplomatic support on Kashmir** and other politico-strategic issues, and as a counterweight to the US in South Asia.
- India's foreign policy focused on **transitioning India from building a socialist society to building a modern capitalist one.** With a growing economy, India started moving towards **prioritizing military and economic power in its foreign policy.**
- Pragmatism was reflected in the growing closeness in the **India-USA relationship which later culminated into the India-USA Nuclear Deal, also known as the 123 Agreement.**

Look East Policy

- India's Look East Policy (LEP), initiated by former Prime Minister **P.V. Narasimha Rao in the early 1990s**, aimed at **reducing India's isolation in international affairs and boosting India's involvement with ASEAN** in order to benefit from the advantages of regional cooperation.

Reasons for Look East Policy:

- **Economically Countering China:** China's trade policies during the 1980s led to its meteoric rise and competition between the countries on many fronts. Thus, India needed to adopt a new economically aggressive policy.

- **Emerging Middle Class:** India has a vast number of educated and talented people forming a huge manpower pool. Thus, India started seeking new markets to export its restless workforce and its products.
- **Containment from West and Central Asia:** The avenues of investment and trade relationship with these regions were under constant threat due to geo-political instability and threat of terrorism.

I.K. Gujral Period

- Gujral's main focus was on **improving India's relationship with its neighbours**. He formulated a set of policies which came to be known as the '**Gujral Doctrine**'.

The Five Principles of the Gujral Doctrine:

1. With the neighbours and other nations, **India should not ask for reciprocity** but should give all that it can, in good faith and trust.
2. To create mutual trust, **no country in the region should allow its soil to be used against the other countries** in any manner.
3. Countries in the region should **respect the sovereignty of each other** and not interfere in the internal matters of any country.
4. **Respecting territorial integrity and sovereignty.**
5. **Mutual resolution** of the bilateral issues without third-party interference.

AB Vajpayee Period

Nuclear Test (1998)

- India has **opposed the international treaties aimed at non-proliferation** since they were selectively applicable to the non-nuclear powers.
- India **opposed the indefinite extension of the NPT in 1995** and also **refused to sign the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT)**.
- India conducted a **series of nuclear tests in May 1998**, demonstrating its capacity to use nuclear energy for military purposes. Pakistan soon followed, and **sanctions were imposed on both India and Pakistan**, which were subsequently waived.
- India's nuclear doctrine of **credible minimum nuclear deterrence** professes '**no first use**' and reiterates India's commitment to global, verifiable and non-discriminatory nuclear disarmament.

Global Response to Nuclear Test

- India's nuclear test invited **strong criticism from the international community**.
- Countries, including the **USA and Japan**, responded with **economic sanctions against India** for the tests and also for going against the NPT and the CTBT.

India's Response:

- India clearly stated its goal that the nuclear testing was to protect her own interest and not directed towards any country.
- India had always maintained its protests against the **discriminatory nature of non-proliferation treaties (NPT and CTBT)**.

India-Pakistan Relations

Bus Diplomacy

- To improve the relationship between India and Pakistan, an innovative idea of introducing a **bus service from New Delhi to Lahore** was started.
- As part of bus diplomacy, **Vajpayee himself travelled all the way to Lahore and signed the Lahore Declaration on 21 February 1999.**

Lahore Declaration (1999)

- India and Pakistan signed the **Lahore Declaration in 1999** with a pledge to work on the principle of **co-operation and coexistence**, and to reduce forces along the Line of Control.

Salient Features:

- It recognized the **nuclear dimension** in the security environment of the two countries.
- Commitment to the principles and purposes of the **Charter of the United Nations**, and the universally accepted principles of peaceful co-existence.
- It reiterates the determination of both countries to implement the **Simla Agreement** in letter and spirit.
- Commitment to the objectives of **universal nuclear disarmament and non-proliferation**.
- It recognized the importance of mutually agreed **confidence-building measures** for improving the security environment.
- It recognized that an environment of peace and security is in the supreme national interest of both sides and that the resolution of all outstanding issues, including **Jammu and Kashmir**, is essential for this purpose.

Kargil Conflict

- Following Pakistan's **armed intrusion in Kargil**, India launched '**Operation Vijay**' to evict the intruders.
- India kept the US informed on the developments. The US called for the withdrawal of the intruders and expressed appreciation for the restraint and responsible manner in which India conducted the operation.

Vajpayee and India-US Relations

- Former US President **Bill Clinton** paid a five-day visit to India in **March 2000** with a view to build dynamic future relations between the two countries.
- The growing economic interaction between India and the US became a major driving force towards mutually beneficial strengthening of relations.

Policy under Manmohan Singh

- By the time Manmohan Singh came to power, **India's foreign policy had changed a lot compared to the Nehru era**. The diplomacy had changed to more benign, friendlier and more outgoing.

Relationship with Russia

- Both countries agreed to establish a **strategic partnership**, with main focus on the military sector, including development of **supersonic cruise missiles BrahMos**, a state-of-the-art 5th Generation Combat Aircraft, and laser guided anti-tank missiles.
- Russia pledged to **build four more civilian nuclear reactors at Kudankulam in Tamil Nadu**.

Relationship with USA

Factors contributing to closer India-USA relations:

- India's disengagement of the privileged relationship with the erstwhile USSR after the disintegration of the Soviet Union.
- Need for counterbalancing the emerging powerful China.
- India's deregulated and liberalised economy also acted as a source of attraction to the US.
- Perceived expansion of terrorist-oriented Islamic fundamentalism in the north-western regions, of which India was perceived as a major target.

India-USA Civil Nuclear Deal

- India and the US signed the historic **India-USA Civil Nuclear Deal**, which:
 - Removed core differences that impeded the strategic relationship for more than 30 years.
 - Supported India's economic growth and energy security in an environmentally sound way.
 - Strengthened the global non-proliferation regime.
- The deal **lifted a three-decade U.S. moratorium on nuclear trade with India**. It provided U.S. assistance to India's civilian nuclear energy program and expanded U.S.-India cooperation in energy and satellite technology.

Salient Features of the Deal:

- India agreed to allow inspectors from the **International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)** access to its civilian nuclear program, placing **fourteen of its twenty-two power reactors** under IAEA safeguards permanently.
- India also committed to safeguard its nuclear arsenal and to prevent it from falling in the wrong hands.
- U.S. companies will be allowed to build nuclear reactors in India and provide nuclear fuel for its civilian energy program.
- India would be eligible to buy U.S. nuclear technology, including materials and equipment that could be used to enrich uranium or reprocess plutonium.
- India committed to signing an **Additional Protocol**, which would allow more intrusive IAEA inspections of its civilian facilities.
- India also agreed to continue its moratorium on nuclear weapons testing.
- In **2008**, the **IAEA Board of Governors approved India's safeguards agreement**, paving the way for India's consideration at the Nuclear Suppliers Group.

Relationship with Pakistan

- The relationship touched a new low with the **2008 Mumbai attacks** and the ensuing evidence that the attackers were backed by the Pakistani military and intelligence establishment.
- To ease tension, a **liberalised visa agreement was signed in September 2012**, allowing citizens from both countries over the age of 65 to be granted a visa on arrival.

Relationship with China

- Chinese Premier **Wen Jiabao visited India in 2005**, leading to signing of the **"Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question"**.
- China officially recognised **Sikkim as an "inalienable part of India"**.
- In **2013**, a **three-week stand-off between India and Chinese troops near the Line of Actual Control between Ladakh and Aksai Chin** was defused when India agreed to demolish the live-in bunkers and China agreed to withdraw its troops.

Manmohan Doctrine

- India's developmental priorities play an important role in guiding our relationship with the world.
- Manmohan Singh stood for the **greater integration of India's economy with the rest of the world** as it will benefit India and enable our people to realize their creative potential.
- India seeks stable, long-term and mutually beneficial relations with all major powers and is prepared to work with the international community to create a global economic and security environment beneficial to all nations.
- The **Indian sub-continent's shared destiny requires greater regional cooperation and connectivity**. Towards this end, India must strengthen regional institutional capability and capacity, and invest in connectivity.

- Our foreign policy is not defined merely by our interests, but also by the values which are very dear to our people.

Foreign Policy under Narendra Modi

- Prime Minister Modi started off with a **bold decision by inviting his counterparts from all SAARC countries to participate in his oath-taking ceremony**, marking a "Neighbourhood First" foreign policy.
- India's foreign policy under Modi demonstrates a marked change and exceptional dynamism. The **4 Ds: Democracy, Demography, Demand and Diaspora** have acted as a force multiplier in India's Foreign Policy under PM Modi.

Features of the Modi Doctrine

Key Principles:

- Transforming the role of India at the international stage to **'a leading power' rather than a mere 'balancing power'**.
- Diplomacy should primarily focus on accelerating a nation's socio-economic development.
- India should also utilise its abundant **soft power**.
- **Indian diaspora is an asset** not limited to just sending remittances; ties with the Indian diaspora should be carefully nurtured.

India First

- 'India First' is the **fundamental feature of the Modi Doctrine**. India's choices and actions are based on the strengths of its national power, guided by a core value of **Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam** (the entire world is our family).

Neighbourhood First Policy

- A determined 'neighbourhood first' approach denotes the **second important feature of the Modi Doctrine**. PM Modi visited all SAARC countries, except Maldives, in his first 19 months, including Pakistan.
- The themes of greater connectivity, stronger cooperation, and broader contacts dominate India's engagement with its neighbours today.

Strengthening Cultural Connect and Soft Power

- Promotion of **Indian values, culture and tradition or civilisational connect** is another important feature of the Modi Doctrine.
- A rare display of India's soft power diplomacy was visible when the entire world along with the United Nations celebrated **International Yoga Day on 21 June**. Modi's initiatives like the **International Solar Alliance** are good examples of soft power augmentation.

Indian Diaspora

- Under PM Modi leadership, the government has **qualitatively and quantitatively enriched engagement with the Indian diaspora**, simplifying rules, quickly responding to their grievances, and engaging them in the overall development agenda.
- Modi's vision of **Sab Ka Sath, Sab Ka Vikas** (take everyone along and work for everyone's development) manifests itself in several layers, multiple themes and different geographies.

Closeness with USA

- In **September 2014**, PM Modi visited the US and in **January 2015**, the US President visited India as chief guest at the Republic Day Parade.
- **Civil Nuclear Agreement**: The deadlock in the Civil Nuclear Agreement was resolved with the Indian liability law amendments and US President's usage of his executive powers.

- **Defence Cooperation:** Both sides agreed to extend the cooperation in the Defence sector for another decade, formally renewing the **'New Framework for Defence Cooperation' in 2015.**
- India signed **LEMOA (Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement)** in **August 2016,** and **COMCASA (Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement)** in **September 2018.**

Look East to Act East

- The Look East Policy has been upgraded by PM Modi to **'Act East'**, to signal greater intent. India's 'Act East' policy has three distinct facets: **institutional, commercial, and security-related.**
- At institutional level, FTA with ASEAN, BIMSTEC and East Asia Summit have integrated India into Asia's multilateral networks. India has also speeded up work on the **3,200 km India-Myanmar-Thailand highway** from Moreh, Manipur as a key artery to bring ASEAN closer to India.

SAGAR Vision

Security and Growth for All in the Region (**SAGAR**) is India's policy or doctrine of maritime cooperation in the Indian Ocean region. First announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on **12 March 2015.**

Vision of SAGAR

PM Modi stated: "Our vision for the Indian Ocean Region is rooted in advancing cooperation in our region and to use our capabilities for the benefit of all in our common maritime home"

- **Security:** Enhancement of coastal security so that land and maritime territories can be safeguarded with relative ease.
- **Capacity Building:** Deepening economic and security cooperation for smooth facilitation of economic trade and maritime security.
- **Collective Action:** Promoting collective action to deal with natural disasters and maritime threats like piracy, terrorism and emergent non-state actors.
- **Sustainable Development:** Working towards sustainable regional development through enhanced collaboration.
- **Maritime Engagement:** Engaging with countries beyond our shores with the aim of building greater trust and promoting respect for maritime rules, norms and peaceful resolution of disputes.

Need for SAGAR Vision

Leveraging Blue Economy

- Blue economy presents India with an unprecedented opportunity to meet its national socio-economic objectives (livelihood generation, achieving energy security, building ecological resilience etc.).
- Oceans provide a substantial portion of the global population with food and livelihood, as well as transportation for **80% of global trade.**
- The seabed currently provides **32% of the global supply of hydrocarbons.** The sea also offers vast potential for renewable blue energy production from wind, wave, tidal, thermal and biomass sources.

Tackling Regional Issues

- There is a need to strengthen efforts to provide humanitarian assistance in wake of natural disasters and counter non-state actors engaged in **piracy and terrorism.**

Checking Chinese Influence

- China through its **maritime silk route (part of the BRI initiative)** has been increasing its influence in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR).
- Moreover, Chinese investments in India's neighboring countries are of **dual nature**: commercial with military underpinnings. The **string of pearls** strategy has caused strategic concerns for India.

Significance of SAGAR Vision

- SAGAR provides a mechanism for India to expand strategic partnerships with other IOR littorals in Asia and Africa.
- SAGAR indicates the leadership role and responsibilities India is ready to play in the region in a transparent manner through its capacity building and capability enhancement programs.
- The key relevance of SAGAR emerges when seen in conjunction with India's other policies impacting the maritime domain like **Act East Policy, Project Sagarmala, Project Mausam, India as 'net security provider', focus on Blue Economy** etc.

Bridging Diplomacy and Development

- Modi's foreign policy is largely driven by India's developmental needs. The focus has been on attracting investors from all over the world towards the **"Make in India"** initiative. In the **2017 financial year, FDI into India reached \$62 billion**.

India's Foreign Policy Challenges

Broad Challenges

- **Ensuring a Peaceful Periphery:** Unless we have a peaceful and prosperous neighbourhood, we won't be able to focus on socio-economic development at the domestic level. The challenge is to build inter-dependencies which not only integrate economies, but also create vested interests in each other's stability and prosperity in the subcontinent.
- **Relations with the Major Powers:** The world today is getting increasingly multipolar with the rise of China. The challenge is to balance relationships with the USA, Russia and China. Growing tilt towards the West will distance time-tested friend Russia. Closeness with Iran and India's stand on Palestine has relevance to its relationship with Israel, US and Arab countries.
- **Food security, water, energy and environment:** These issues are cross-boundary issues which require India to engage constructively with others to address them holistically. Our economic growth requires sustained supply of energy for which we need to engage with energy-surplus countries.

Current Challenges to India's Foreign Policy

- **Russia-Ukraine Issue:** It is certainly a complex international political issue when countries like India find it difficult to choose between politics and moral imperative. Russia is a trade partner, and it has leverage in the Eurasian region. As realist prudence demands, India cannot simply undertake a moralist standpoint on the Russia-Ukraine Conflict and ignore the dictates of politics.
- **Internal Challenges:** A country cannot be powerful abroad if it is weak at home. India's soft power assets make sense when they are supported by its hard power.
- **Refugee Crisis:** In spite of not being a party to the **1951 Refugee Convention** and its **1967 Protocol**, India has been one of the largest recipients of refugees in the world. The challenge is to balance protection of human rights and national interest.

Cultural Diplomacy

Cultural Diplomacy is one of the important strategies **to achieve foreign policy objectives, helping to establish good relationships with other countries** powered by official initiatives as well as people-to-people contact.

Significance

- Cultural diplomacy leads to promotion of values and image of a country amongst other countries and leads to understanding of values, culture and image of other countries and their people.
- Cultural diplomacy can lead to strong connections between people of different countries as it can create forums for interaction between people, thus creating a **"foundation of trust"** with other peoples.
- Policy makers can build on this trust to create political, economic, and military agreements. Cultural diplomacy can also help reduce ethnic clashes between different communities.

India's Cultural Diplomacy and Soft Power

- Since Independence, India has recognized the importance of cultural diplomacy. The Ministry of External Affairs has been promoting India's culture, resulting in India signing **126 bilateral cultural agreements** with many countries and currently implements **58 Cultural Exchange Programmes** with other countries.
- Towards this goal, India established the **Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR) in 1950**. ICCR has a presence in **35 countries** in the form of cultural centres.
- Since the 1990s, India's culture has been generating a lot of interest around the world with the acceptance of **Indian cuisines, Yoga, Bollywood** and also contemporary art.
- The government has been focusing on the Indian diaspora through various initiatives including **Pravasi Bhartiya Diwas** which was started in 2003. Another major program '**Know India Program**' is a three-week orientation program focusing on diaspora youth.

Present Scenario

- "Cultural and civilisation links" denote the **soft power components of India's foreign policy under Modi**.
- The UNGA accepted India's proposal, adopting **Yoga as International Yoga Day on 21 June** of every year. The same push has also been given to **Ayurveda**, aiming to establish it at par with traditional Chinese medicine.
- Bollywood has also played a significant role in promoting India's culture as the industry saw a greater acceptance on the international platform.

Sports Diplomacy

Sports diplomacy describes the **use of sports as a means to influence diplomatic, social, and political relations**, which transcends cultural differences and brings people together.

- India and Pakistan started playing cricket with each other in **1952**. Former Pakistan President **Zia ul-Haq** started cricket diplomacy when he came to India to watch a Test match in **February 1987** as part of his "cricket for peace initiative".
- In **2005**, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh used cricket diplomacy when he **invited Pakistan President Parvez Musharraf to watch a one-day match in Delhi**. The occasion provided space to talk about a range of issues including Kashmir, and conflicts over Siachen and Sir Creek.
- In general, cricket diplomacy has provided a platform to resume talks on a wide range of issues and also evaluate the mood of both the nations, helping in **building confidence between the two countries and their people**.

Space Diplomacy

Space diplomacy can be described as the **exploitation of space technology as a means to influence diplomatic, social, and political relations**. ISRO has space cooperation documents with space agencies of **39 countries and 4 multinational bodies**.

- **Satellite Systems and Rockets:** ISRO has been working with **CNES (French space agency), NASA and the Russian space agency** on various fronts. ISRO is also collaborating with NASA to develop **NISAR (NASA-ISRO Synthetic Aperture Radar)**, a joint microwave remote sensing satellite for Earth Observation.
- **Satellite Communications:** Towards 'Neighbourhood First' Policy, PM Modi gifted the **South Asia Satellite (SAS)** to Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, the Maldives, Nepal and Sri Lanka to boost communication and improve disaster links.
- **Satellite Data and Disaster Management:** ISRO has also been cooperating with ASEAN through **COSPAS-SARSAT**: a search and rescue system. ISRO shares data from Indian satellites, supporting their search and rescue operations.
- **Satellite Navigation:** With the deployment of **IRNSS (NAVIC)**, India is in a position to extend services like terrestrial and marine navigation, disaster management, vehicle tracking, and navigation aid for hikers and travellers to the neighbours.
- **Capacity Building:** ISRO has also been engaged in building capacity of other countries by sharing its facilities and expertise through the **Indian Institute of Remote Sensing (IIRS)** and the UN affiliated **Centre for Space Science and Technology Education in Asia and the Pacific (CSSTE-AP)** at Dehradun.

Economic Diplomacy

Economic diplomacy refers to **use of all the economic tools like export, import, investment, lending, aid, free trade agreements, etc. to further the national interest**. It basically employs economic resources, as rewards or sanctions, to achieve a particular foreign policy target.

- Before liberalization, the focus of economic diplomacy was to ensure enough flow of foreign currency to bridge the foreign exchange gap.
- The reforms initiated in **1991** have significantly transformed India's foreign policy template, opening up unprecedented prospects for India's external relations.
- With East Asia, economic engagement has been the pillar of India's Act East Policy. FTA with ASEAN and connectivity projects like **BBIN, IMT trilateral highways** are aimed at strengthening economic integration with the region.
- At the WTO, India is seen as one of the **major voices of dissent from the developing world**. India's stand on **public stockholding, minimum support price (MSP) and subsidy** reflects the national interest.

Defence Diplomacy

Defence Diplomacy is any military activity with an expressly diplomatic purpose; activities where the primary objective is to **promote goodwill towards India in other countries**. Defence diplomacy covers a broad range of activities including:

- Ministry of Defence training courses and education programmes, including opportunities for overseas students.
- Provision for loaning service personnel, short-term training teams, and civilian and military advisers being seconded to foreign governments.
- Visits by ships, aircraft and other military units.
- Inward and outward visits by ministers and by military and civilian personnel at all levels.
- Staff talks, conferences and seminars to improve mutual understanding.
- Exercises and joint military drills.

- The basic principles of India's foreign policy and defence diplomacy have been: **no territorial ambitions and no export of ideologies including democracy.**
- Defence partnership with **Russia, Israel, France, USA** and others showcase the strategic autonomy maintained by India in its defence cooperation with these countries.

India's Contemporary Security Challenges

- **Cross-Border Terrorism:** Most external threats emanate from an unsettled boundary dispute with China and ongoing cross-border Jihadi terrorism in J&K, supported by ISI and Pakistan-based Islamist fundamentalist organizations like **Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammad**, who in turn are inextricably linked with international jihadi groups like Taliban and Al Qaida.
- **International Terrorism:** India has suffered the most gruesome and repeated acts of terror since the late 1970s. While in most parts of the world, terrorism is perpetrated by non-state actors, in India it is **sponsored and supported by state agencies from a hostile neighbourhood.**
- **ISIS:** The **Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS)** is a Sunni militant jihadist outfit predominantly active in Iraq and Syria. To prevent the group from gaining a foothold, India needs **high-level intelligence and counter-terror operations.** Equally important is better coordination between the state and Muslim religious leaders in countering radicalisation.
- **Maritime Security:** The national and economic interests of India are inseparably linked up with the Indian Ocean. Maritime domain challenges include non-state actors, piracy, presence of China in littoral countries, and freedom of navigation.
- **Cyber Security:** India's vulnerability to cyber-attacks will increase in the future due to increasing digital penetration and push for cashless transactions. **Cyber-attacks (Malware, Ransomware etc.)** on Critical Infrastructures have the ability to cause huge damage to nations' economy as well as security architecture.
- **Drug Trafficking:** Proximity to the largest producers of heroin and hashish, namely the **Golden Triangle and Golden Crescent (Afghanistan-Pakistan-Iran)**, has made India's border vulnerable to drug trafficking.
- **Nuclear Threat:** India, with its commitment to no first use of nuclear weapons, has not utilized nuclear weapons to substitute for or complement other forms of force or coercion. However, rapid improvement in nuclear capabilities by Pakistan and gradual nuclear modernization by China have changed India's national security environment.

Previous Years' Questions (UPSC Mains)

1. "Critically examine the major factors responsible for a turnaround in the trajectory of India's foreign policy in the post-cold war period." **(2022)**
2. "Critically analyze the different phases of India's foreign policy since independence. How justified, do you think, is the classification of the current phase as the phase of 'energetic diplomacy'?" **(2025)**
3. "Would you concur with the view that of late, India's foreign policy has been in a transition mode from Nehruvianism to Neoliberalism? Support your answer with the help of suitable examples." **(2024)**
4. "Evaluate the economic and strategic dimensions of India's Look East Policy in the context of the post-Cold War international scenario." **(2016)**
5. "Mainstreaming Hard Power in India's Foreign Policy Architecture is an essential component of 'India's Rise as a Global Power.' Discuss." **(2023)**
6. "In the context of the changing international political order, India has emerged as a leader of the Global South. Discuss the challenges and opportunities India faces in this role." **(2024)**